

New Cat First Weeks Survival Guide — Action Checklist

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PREPARE THE SANCTUARY ROOM

- ☐ **Prepare the Sanctuary Room:** Set up one room as the sanctuary space with a litter box placed away from food, a water station, one hiding spot like an open carrier with a cushion, and their food bowl to avoid overwhelming your stressed cat with the entire house at once.
- ☐ **Prepare the Sanctuary Room:** Plug in a Feliway diffuser in the sanctuary room near the hiding spot to help reduce your cat's stress through synthetic calming pheromones that mimic the hormones cats produce when they feel safe in familiar territory.
- ☐ **Prepare the Sanctuary Room:** Keep blinds and curtains closed in the sanctuary room during the first week to prevent visual stress from outside movement, birds, people, and other cats triggering persistent alertness and anxiety in your newly adopted cat.
- ☐ **Prepare the Sanctuary Room:** Place the litter box away from food and water stations in the sanctuary room to follow your cat's natural preferences and encourage consistent litter box use during the critical first week of adjustment.

BUILD THE NIGHTTIME ROUTINE

- ☐ **Build the Nighttime Routine:** Move your cat's final meal of the day to your bedtime (10:30pm or 11pm) to align with their natural drowsiness cycle since digestion causes drowsiness while eating earlier leaves a four-hour alertness window.
- ☐ **Build the Nighttime Routine:** Conduct a 15-minute active play session before the final meal each night using a wand toy or laser pointer to exhaust the hunting instinct before satisfying it with food, which triggers natural drowsiness.
- ☐ **Build the Nighttime Routine:** Do not respond to nighttime crying for the first 30 minutes after you go to bed since any response, even negative attention, registers as reinforcement and will strengthen the behavior you are trying to eliminate.

- **Build the Nighttime Routine:** Maintain the nighttime sequence of play, final meal, and lights out at the same time every single day because cats learn through routine consistency and irregular schedules will extend the adjustment period significantly.

TRACK PROGRESS AND EXPAND

- **Track Progress and Expand:** Watch for specific signs of good progress including shorter nighttime crying sessions, consistent daytime eating, your cat coming out of hiding more often, and regular litter box usage before expanding their territory.
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- **Track Progress and Expand:** Call your vet immediately if your cat is straining to urinate, has not eaten for 24 or more hours, has been hiding without coming out for more than three days, or shows visible aggression with hissing and swatting.
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- **Track Progress and Expand:** Once your cat is eating and using the litter box reliably by day 5-7, add a cat tree near a window and a second litter box in a different location to provide additional enrichment and resources.
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- **Track Progress and Expand:** Begin opening one new room per day only after consistent improvement appears, starting with 30-minute exploration sessions before closing the room, and let your cat set the pace rather than rushing the process.
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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.